Mise *en* Place

The Workbook

A planning method for people who run more than one life at once

THIS WORKBOOK BELONGS TO

STARTED ON

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MISE EN PLACE

Before you begin

Every good kitchen starts the same way. Before service, the cook sets out everything the night will need: knives sharpened, sauces reduced, stations clean. When the rush comes, they don't think about logistics. They think about the plate.

This workbook applies that discipline to a working life. It rests on three questions, asked before any action: **Result** — what do I actually want? **Reason** — why does it matter to me? **Route** — what is the simplest path there?

Write in it. The exercises are short on purpose, and the writing is where the change happens. One module a week is the right pace for most people.

MODULE 0

00 Orientation

Know where you are starting from.

Answer quickly. First instincts are more useful than considered ones here. You will score yourself again at the end of Module 7.

EXERCISE 0.1

Your baseline

Rate each statement from 1 (rarely true) to 5 (almost always true).

At the start of most days, I know the three things that matter most.	1	2	3	4	5
At the end of most weeks, I feel I moved something important forward.	1	2	3	4	5
My calendar reflects what I say my priorities are.	1	2	3	4	5
I spend most of my working hours on work only I can do.	1	2	3	4	5
I have regular time for the people and things that restore me.	1	2	3	4	5
When my plans fall apart, I can rebuild them quickly.	1	2	3	4	5
I know why my current main goals matter to me personally.	1	2	3	4	5

Total (out of 35)

EXERCISE 0.2

Finish the sentences

The part of my life that gets the least intentional attention is...

The thing I keep saying I'll get to is...

I'm at my best when...

My one specific reason for doing this course is...

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

For three days, notice the moments you feel busy but not useful. Write a word each time.

MODULE 1

01 Planning as Design

A plan isn't a list of what you'll do. It's a decision about what kind of life you're building.

Most planning keeps you organised inside the life you already have. Design starts somewhere else: from the experience you want to create, working back to the details that will produce it.

So every planning session begins with a different question. Not "What do I need to do?" but "What do I want to be true?"

KEEP IN MIND

- Busy is not the same as moving.
- Shoulds rarely happen. Change begins when a standard is no longer acceptable to you — when a should becomes a must.
- Name your life areas in your own words. Names that sound like you hold your attention.

EXERCISE 1.1

The long list

Twelve minutes, without stopping. Everything you'd like to be, do, have, learn, experience or give. Then write a timeframe beside each: 1, 3, 5, 10 or 20 years. Circle the four or five one-year items that excite you most.

EXERCISE 1.2

Your Life Map

Five to seven areas. Write the vision in the present tense, as if it were already true.

AREA	VISION	CURRENT STANDARD	ROLE AT MY BEST	SCORE /10

EXERCISE 1.3

The gap

Which area, if it improved by two points, would lift every other area with it? (This is your lead area.)

Which area have I been quietly neglecting because another one is louder?

Which current standard is no longer acceptable to me?

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

Read your Life Map each morning before opening any messages. Ninety seconds.

MODULE 2

02 Why Lists Fail

A list can tell you what to do. It can't tell you why — so it can't tell you what matters.

Lists hold tasks, not outcomes. They grow faster than you can clear them, reward whoever asked last, and carry no reason to act today rather than next week.

Time is also felt, not just measured. An hour of clarity and an hour of anxiety are the same on a clock and very different in a life. Clarity creates time.

KEEP IN MIND

- Overwhelm is a signal that you are trying to deal with everything at once. The answer is to choose.
- "I don't have time" is often a state, not a fact. Try "That isn't a priority right now."
- The fastest way to get more done is to do less. Decide in advance what you won't do.

EXERCISE 2.1

The list autopsy

Mark each item on your current list: R (moves a vision forward), M (maintenance), O (someone else's priority), ? (can't remember why).

R	M	O	?	TOTAL

EXERCISE 2.2

Reactivity Audit — five evenings

DAY	MOST IMPORTANT THING I MOVED	TIME THAT DIDN'T NEED TO BE MINE	WHEN I FELT IN CONTROL

Three patterns I notice

EXERCISE 2.3

Your Not-To-Do list

At least seven things you have decided to stop doing.

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.
6.
7.

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

Each morning, before looking at your list, write: "Today will be a good day if..." Do the matching item first.

MODULE 3

03 The Three Questions

Decide what you want and why before deciding what to do. The plan becomes shorter, clearer and easier to follow.

Result is an outcome, not an activity: something you could see and confirm is done. **Reason** is the fuel — personal, emotional, and written in more than one layer. **Route** is the short list of actions, with the essential few marked as musts.

A complete Reason looks at both sides: what you gain if you do it, and what it costs you if the pattern continues. Lead with what you want; use the cost as a push when the pull isn't enough.

KEEP IN MIND

- Five tests of a Result: is it an outcome, specific, yours, the right size — and does it pull you?
- If you could only do two actions on the Route, which two?
- Before every meeting, agree the outcome first.

EXERCISE 3.1

A full plan

Write one for your lead area. Copy this page for a work plan and a personal plan.

Result

What I gain

What it costs me if I don't

Which of my values it serves

ACTION	MUST	TIME	WHO	WHEN

EXERCISE 3.2

Task translation

Take ten items from your list. Ask “What result is this in service of?” until you reach something meaningful — or nothing.

TASK	THE RESULT BEHIND IT	KEEP / MAINTAIN / DELETE

THIS WEEK’S PRACTICE

Before any block of work longer than 30 minutes, write Result, Reason, Route in the margin. One line each.

MODULE 4

04 From Capture to Commitment

Once a week, empty your head, group everything by the result it serves, and commit to the essential few.

The Weekly Mise en Place takes sixty minutes and has five stages: capture, group, plan, commit, prepare. If you keep only one habit from this course, keep this one.

Before grouping, sort each item once: discard, delegate, do (if under two minutes), date, file, or stop it arriving. A third of most lists disappears here.

KEEP IN MIND

- Give your musts your best hours, before the inbox.
- Protect at least one high-value, non-urgent task every day. It is where the future is built.
- A clear, courteous no builds more trust than a yes you can't honour.

EXERCISE 4.1

Your first weekly session

Use the Weekly Mise en Place tool at the back. Then reflect.

ITEMS CAPTURED	GROUPS FORMED	MUST HOURS BEFORE CUTTING	AFTER CUTTING

How I felt at the start — and at the end

EXERCISE 4.2

Triage

P1: serious consequences today. P2: high value, not urgent. P3: someone will be disappointed eventually. P4: doesn't matter.

P1	P2	P3	P4

EXERCISE 4.3

A no I need to say

The request

What I'll say — warm, clear, under sixty words

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

Write the Daily Card every morning before the inbox. Protect one block of must time every working day.

MODULE 5

05 Leverage

Your time should go where only you can add value. Everything else can be stopped, simplified, systemised, handed over — or learned from someone who has done it.

Every hour spent on work someone else could do is an hour not spent on the relationships, decisions and standards only you can provide.

Start with an 80/20 map: which few clients, products or activities produce most of your results — and which take most of your time? The mismatches are where leverage hides.

KEEP IN MIND

- Hand over a Result with its Reason, not a task.
- A good handover has five parts: result, reason, boundaries, resources, check-in.
- Decide in writing what you'll do with the hours you free, or they will fill back up.

EXERCISE 5.1

Your 80/20 map

	PRODUCES A LOT	PRODUCES LITTLE
Takes a lot of my time		
Takes little of my time		

EXERCISE 5.2

Your Leverage Ledger

Five items where a lever would free the most time or energy.

ACTIVITY	HRS/WK	LEVER	FIRST STEP	BY WHEN	HRS FREED

What I'll do with the freed hours

EXERCISE 5.3

One proper handover

Result — what "done well" looks like

Reason — why it matters

Boundaries — budget, deadline, what they decide alone

Resources — templates, contacts, examples

Check-in — date and what we'll review

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

Each time you start a task, ask: "Is this only-me work?" If not, add it to the Ledger.

06

MODULE 6

Time, Focus and State

Your calendar shows what you actually prioritise. Your state decides how well you execute. Design both on purpose.

Time targets reverse the usual order: decide how much of each week every area of your life deserves, and book those minimums first.

State is a working asset. Sleep, food and movement come first. Then three levers: your body, the questions you ask yourself, and your breath.

KEEP IN MIND

- Single-task in 45-minute rounds. Keep a list of ten-minute tasks for the gaps.
- When something goes wrong, ask: what's useful here? what isn't right yet? what will I do — and stop doing? how can I enjoy fixing it?
- Two-minute heart breath: attention on the chest, five seconds in, five out, a feeling of real gratitude. Ten breaths.

EXERCISE 6.1

Time targets

AREA	MINIMUM / WEEK	IDEAL / WEEK	WHERE IN THE WEEK

EXERCISE 6.2

Your Restoratives Menu

The small things that reliably return you to your best state.

Small plates · 1–5 minutes

Mains · 15–60 minutes

Tasting menus · half a day or more

EXERCISE 6.3

My ideal working day

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

Live by your time targets for five days. Use one small plate before each block of must time.

MODULE 7

07 The Long Game

A system is only as good as the rituals that keep it alive. Build a few, keep them simple, and use them for years.

Write your own rules for winning — rules you can meet regularly, that make it easy to feel good and hard to feel bad. Then keep the rhythm: a daily card, a weekly hour, a quarterly review.

Each morning, rehearse. Picture today's three Results done well, and yourself at your best inside them. Feel it before it happens, then carry that into the first must.

KEEP IN MIND

- When you drift, don't restart with a new system. Do the 20-minute reset: capture, pick three, one must.
- When your state is the problem, run the ten-day reset: no dwelling, solutions first, begin again if you slip.

EXERCISE 7.1

My rules for winning

1. I win when...
2. I win when...
3. I win when...
4. I win when...
5. I win when...
6. I win when...

EXERCISE 7.2

My values, in order

STATES I WANT TO FEEL MOST	STATES I MOST WANT TO AVOID

EXERCISE 7.3

Your baseline, again

Return to Module 0 and score the seven statements again.

SCORE THEN	SCORE NOW

What changed most

The part of the method I'll work hardest to keep

THIS WEEK'S PRACTICE

Book the rhythm now: 13 weekly sessions, three monthly look-backs, and your first Quarterly Review.

MISE EN PLACE

Tools

Copy these pages as often as you need. They are the working parts of the method.

TOOLS

Weekly Mise en Place

Sixty minutes, same time every week.

1 · Capture — everything on my mind (10 min)

2 · Sort and group — discard, delegate, do, date, file, stop (10 min)

RESULT THIS WEEK	REASON	MUSTS	HOURS

4 · Must-time blocks booked

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI

- [ ] Musts fit the time I really have
- [ ] Time targets checked
- [ ] One restorative booked

- [ ] Tomorrow's Daily Card written

TOOLS

Daily Card

Ten minutes in the morning. Two in the evening.

Morning questions — grateful for · looking forward to · proud of · who I love · committed to

Today will be a good day if...

RESULT	MUSTS, IN ORDER	P1–P4	DONE

Protected block · message windows · if the day turns, I'll let go of

Evening — what I gave · what I learned · one win · tomorrow's first action

TOOLS

Quarterly Review

Two to three hours, every thirteen weeks.

Celebrate — everything that went well

WHAT DIDN'T GO TO PLAN	WHAT IT TAUGHT ME

AREA	SCORE THEN	SCORE NOW	NEXT QUARTER'S RESULT

- [ ] Time targets adjusted
- [ ] Leverage Ledger reviewed
- [ ] Restoratives Menu refreshed
- [ ] Rules for winning still true
- [ ] Next review booked

One sentence for the quarter ahead

The method is simple on purpose. What makes it work is the same thing that makes a great hotel or a great café work: consistency in the details, done with care, until it becomes simply how things are done. Set your station. Then cook.